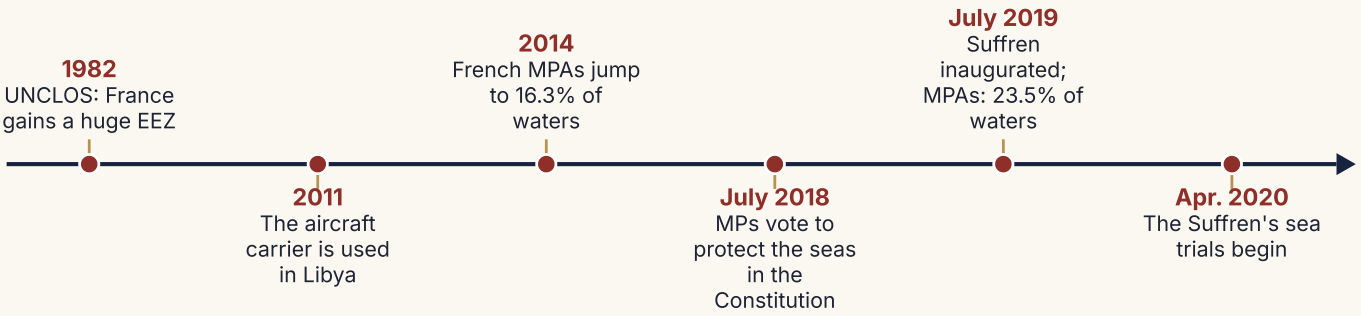
DNL HISTORY-GEOGRAPHY · TERMINALE BFI · M. ROS

G3 France: a great maritime power

Theme 1 — Maritime Areas and Geopolitics at the Heart of a Globalised World

Objective. Assess what makes France a great maritime power, what is at stake for it at sea, and its limits.

Dates to know



The big picture

France owes its maritime power to its overseas territories, which give it the second largest EEZ in the world (10.7 million km², 62% in the Pacific), and to a first-rank navy — a nuclear aircraft carrier, nuclear submarines, bases on every ocean and abroad. It has world-class companies (CMA CGM) and shipyards (Saint-Nazaire), but its shipbuilding has declined and its ports remain middle-ranking. Its stakes are to appropriate and extend its EEZ, to secure its maritime space and energy supplies, to modernise its ports and to protect the sea: a great maritime power, between power and fear of decline.

KEY ISSUES

- With reference to Britain or France, and other examples you have studied, assess the role of maritime powers in international maritime space.

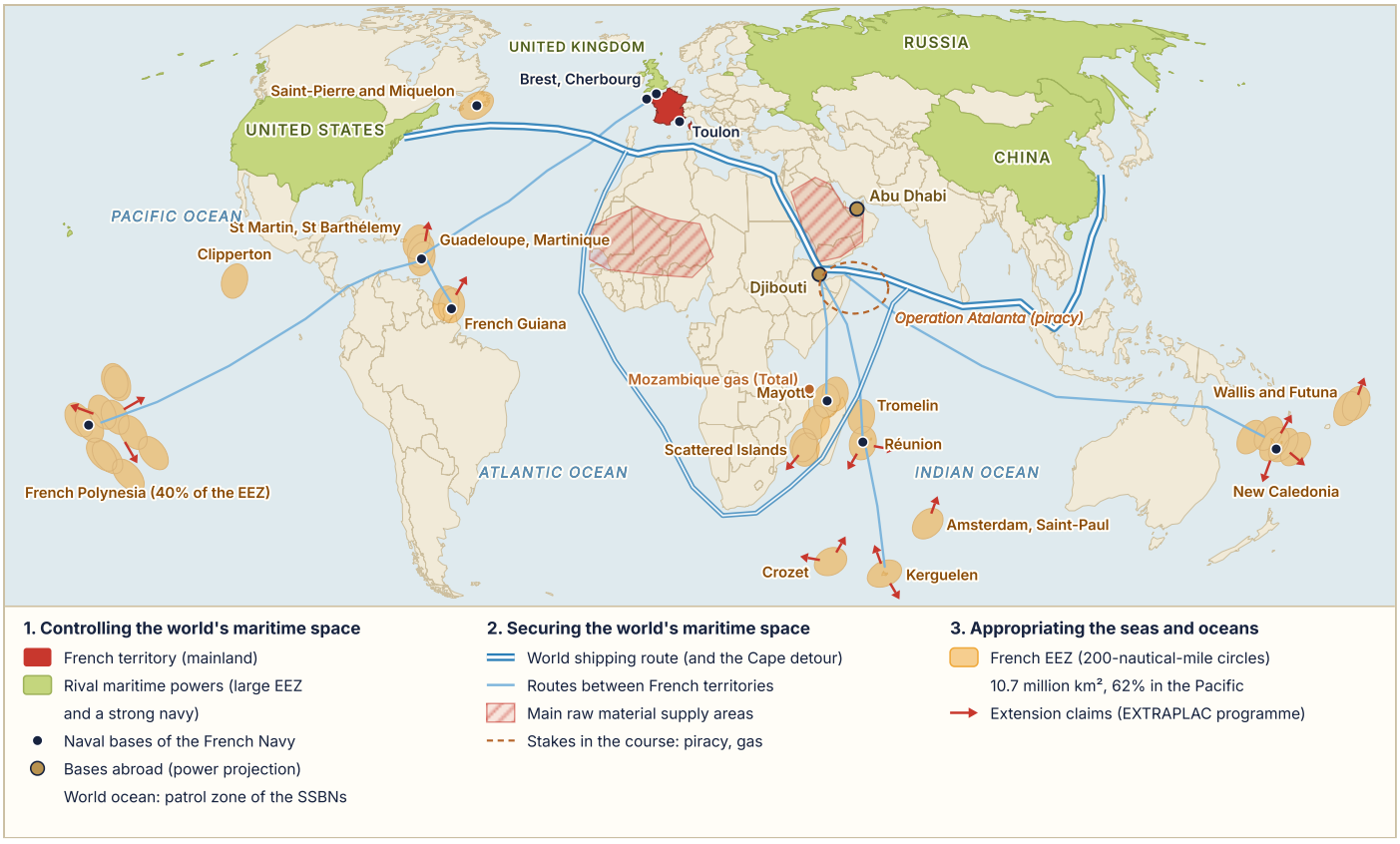
KEY TERMS

Maritime Power

Summary diagram — A great maritime power, between power and fear of decline

	Strengths	Limits
Territory and EEZ	2nd EEZ (10.7 M km²), on every ocean; EXTRAPLAC	Mostly distant territories (97% overseas)
Navy	Nuclear carrier (with the USA only), 4 SSBNs, 5 SSNs, bases abroad	Equipment costly to renew
Merchant navy, shipyards	CMA CGM, 3rd in the world; Saint-Nazaire's cruise ships	Ships under other flags; shipbuilding lost to Asia
Ports	66 ports; Fos 4XL	Marseille 53rd, Le Havre 68th; far from the Northern Range
Economy and resources	2.5% of GDP, 300,000 jobs; 3rd in Europe for fishing	Little offshore oil; marine renewables only 800 jobs
Protection	546 MPAs, 23.5% of waters (2019); Scandola	The 2018 constitutional reform never completed

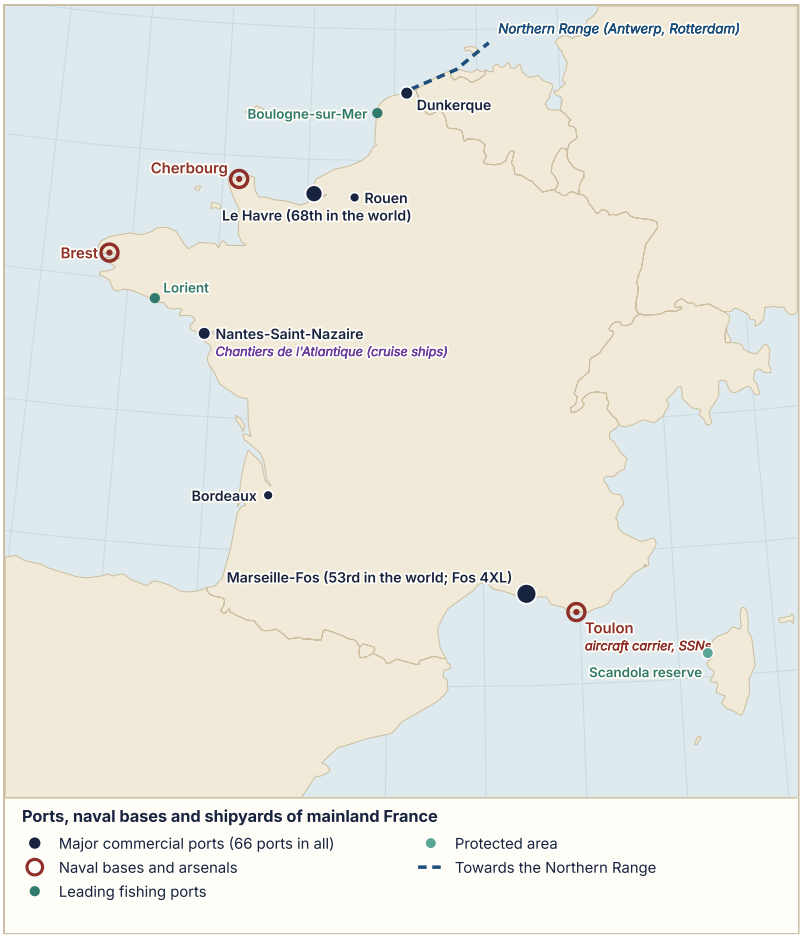
Summary map — France, a great maritime power



1. EEZ of 10.7 million km², the 2nd in the world: 62% in the Pacific, 40% for French Polynesia alone; 97% of the maritime space is overseas.
2. Bases on every ocean and abroad (Djibouti, Abu Dhabi); a nuclear aircraft carrier, 4 SSBNs, 5 SSNs.
3. EXTRAPLAC: requests to extend the continental shelf; Atalanta against piracy; Total's gas off Mozambique.

After the course's map (French Navy and Ministry for the Overseas, 2019); EEZ approximated by 200-nautical-mile circles.

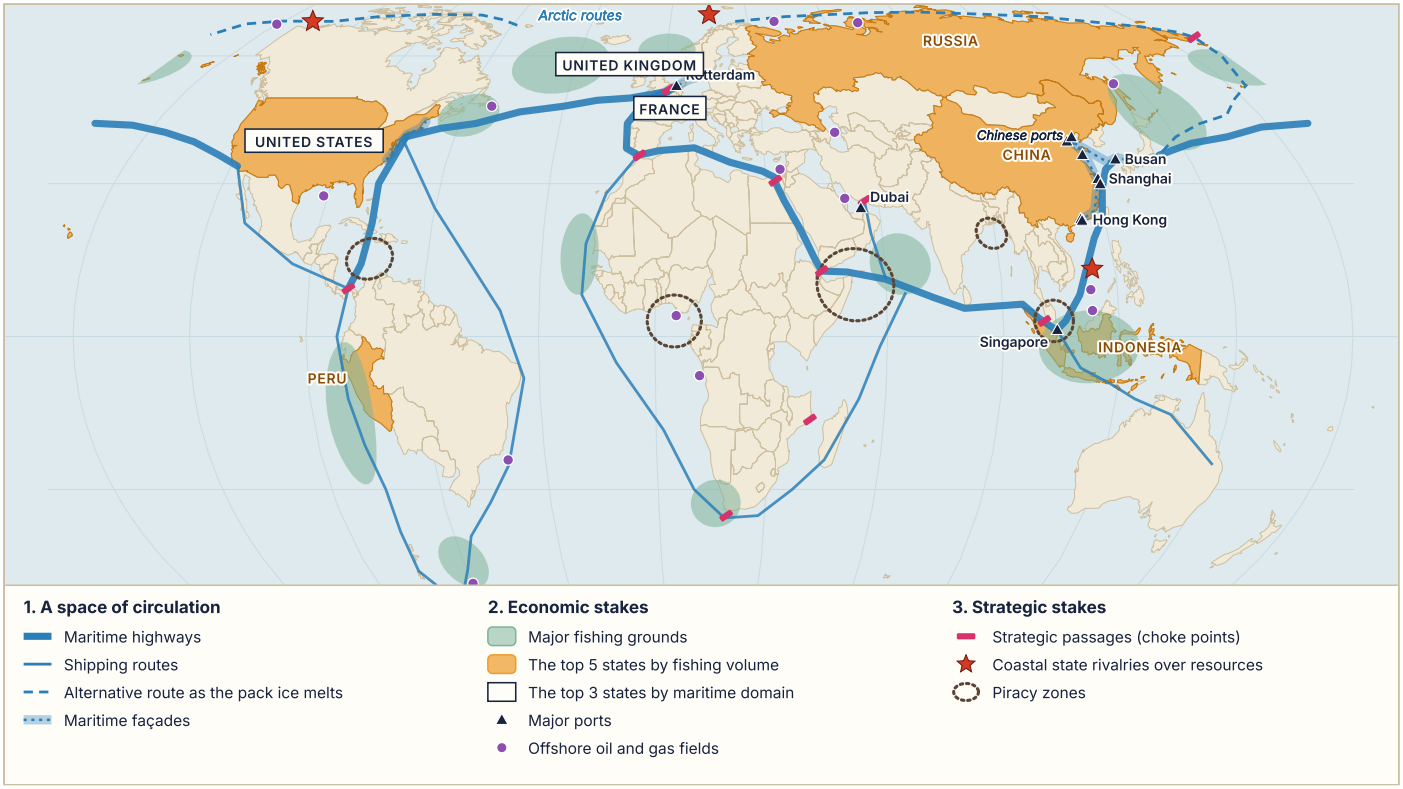
Zoom — Ports, naval bases and shipyards of mainland France



1. 66 ports; Marseille-Fos (Fos 4XL) and Le Havre are only 53rd and 68th in the world; far from the Northern Range.
2. Toulon, the most active arsenal (carrier, SSNs); Brest, Cherbourg; Chantiers de l'Atlantique at Saint-Nazaire.

Natural Earth base map; fishing ports from the course's map.

Summary of the theme — Maritime areas in globalisation



1. A ready-made essay plan: 1) a space of circulation, 2) economic stakes, 3) strategic stakes.
2. On the course's map, the top three maritime domains: the United States, the United Kingdom, France.

After the course's summary map; Arctic routes cut by the edge of the map.

V.1 The aspects of French maritime power

Present on every ocean, through its overseas territories and its power projection

What makes a maritime power? First, presence on every ocean. France has it in two ways: through its overseas territories, scattered across the Atlantic, the Indian Ocean and the Pacific, and through power projection — naval bases abroad and an aircraft carrier able to sail anywhere.

> **EXAMPLE** Overseas territories on three oceans: the Antilles, French Guiana and Saint-Pierre-and-Miquelon (Atlantic); Réunion, Mayotte, the Scattered Islands and the French Southern Lands (Indian Ocean); New Caledonia, French Polynesia, Wallis-and-Futuna and Clipperton (Pacific). Bases abroad: Djibouti and Abu Dhabi.

A navy of the first rank: nuclear aircraft carrier and nuclear submarines

France has a navy of the first rank. It is the only power, with the United States, to have a nuclear-powered aircraft carrier. It has four ballistic missile submarines (SSBNs, "sous-marins nucléaires lanceurs d'engins") — like the United States, Russia, the United Kingdom, China and India — which carry nuclear deterrence, and five attack submarines.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** The aircraft carrier Charles de Gaulle was used in Libya in 2011. The nuclear attack submarine Suffren, inaugurated in July 2019 and tested at sea from April 2020, is the first of a new generation, built at Cherbourg, a shipyard specialised in military vessels. By tonnage, the French navy is the sixth in the world (319,195 t, G2). (Name of the carrier added from outside the course.)

A merchant navy embodied by CMA CGM — French by its headquarters more than by its ships

France has a world-class shipping company, CMA CGM, the third container shipping company in the world, whose headquarters is in Marseille. But it is French by its headquarters and decision centres much more than by the flag of its ships, its crews or its capital: globalisation blurs the nationality of shipping.

> **EXAMPLE** The CMA CGM tower dominates the port of Marseille. The company's ships, like the CMA CGM Notre Dame, are built in China, and many sail under other flags (G1, I.1).

Shipyards in decline, except for the giants of cruise ships and warships

French shipbuilding has declined to the benefit of Asian shipyards (South Korea, then China). It survives in niches of excellence: very large cruise ships and military vessels.

> **EXAMPLE** The Chantiers de l'Atlantique at Saint-Nazaire, one of the world's largest shipyards, specialise in cruise ships: more than 3,000 employees build the biggest cruise ships in the world. Cherbourg builds submarines such as the Suffren.

The resources of the sea: fishing, energy and minerals

French maritime power also rests on the resources of the sea: fishing, energy and minerals. France has major fishing ports on the Channel and the Atlantic, but few offshore fossil-fuel reserves.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** Boulogne-sur-Mer and Lorient are the leading French fishing ports. (Port names added from outside the course: the course shows them on a map.)

66 ports, but none among the world's giants, and far from the Northern Range

France has 66 ports. Marseille and Le Havre are the two main ones, but few French ports are connected to the European "maritime façade" of the Northern Range, which lies to the north (Antwerp, Rotterdam). French ports remain modest by world standards.

> **EXAMPLE** Marseille and Le Havre are only the 53rd and 68th ports in the world by tonnage.

The maritime economy: 2.5% of GDP and 300,000 direct jobs

Maritime power is also an economy. The course's infographic counts about 300,000 direct jobs and 2.5% of France's GDP. Fishing and sea products employ the most people, ahead of shipbuilding, boating, ports, defence, oil and maritime transport; the activities of the future — marine renewable energies, mineral resources — still weigh very little. France is the 3rd European country for fishing, but it imports much more seafood than it exports.

> **EXAMPLE** Direct jobs: fishing, aquaculture, sea products and biotechnologies 64,823; shipbuilding and naval activities 42,000; recreational boating 40,166; commercial ports 39,000; defence and state action at sea 30,000; oil 29,000; maritime transport 22,000; marine renewable energies only 800 and marine mineral resources 700. The French eat 34 kg of seafood per person per year; imports reach €6 billion against €1.6 billion of exports (Mer et Marine, 2017, and gouvernement.fr, 2018).

V.2 Geostrategic stakes

Appropriating the sea: the second largest EEZ in the world

Thanks to its overseas territories, France has an EEZ of about 10.7 million km², the second in the world, which explains how it can claim to be "the second maritime power in the world". 62% of the French EEZ lies in the Pacific; French Polynesia alone accounts for 40%. Enlarging the EEZ is a territorial stake: the EXTRAPLAC programme asks for the extension of the continental shelf. The question is the appropriation of the resources of the sea: fishing, and potential seabed minerals and energy.

> **EXAMPLE** The French EEZ even includes the first shipping route in the world, which links Northern Europe to Asia through Gibraltar and the Suez Canal (in the Channel and the Mediterranean). (Video of the course: "Comment la France peut-elle être la 2e puissance maritime mondiale ?", 4 min.)

Controlling and securing maritime space: naval bases on every ocean

France has naval bases on every ocean: overseas (Martinique, French Guiana, Réunion, New Caledonia, French Polynesia), in the mainland (Toulon, Brest, Cherbourg) and abroad (Djibouti, Abu Dhabi). Securing its maritime space means renewing equipment — a military and a financial stake —, adapting to a new world geopolitics (the pivot towards Asia), fighting piracy and watching over a huge EEZ.

> **EXAMPLE** The Toulon arsenal is the most active today, because it is close to the theatres of operation, especially the Middle East: it is the home port of the aircraft carrier Charles de Gaulle and of the nuclear attack submarines. France takes part in Operation Atalanta against piracy, and watches over its EEZ as far as Wallis-and-Futuna (video of the course, 3 min). The course's map of French maritime power sums up the logic of this part: control the world's maritime space (bases, submarines on patrol), secure it (the world shipping route, the routes between French territories, the raw material supply areas of West Africa and the Arabian Peninsula), appropriate it (the EEZ and its extension requests).

New energy stakes: securing supplies by sea, developing marine renewables

France has no significant offshore fossil-fuel reserves, but the EEZ of the Scattered Islands (in the Mozambique Channel) is promising for gas. The real stake is to secure energy supplies by sea. Marine renewable energies are a potential to develop.

> **EXAMPLE** The French company Total is the first gas operator in Africa and is developing the huge gas reserves discovered off Mozambique.

Modernising the ports to stay competitive

Modernisation projects, financed by the State and local authorities, aim to keep French ports competitive in globalisation and to diversify their activities (cruise tourism). The State also maintains naval military-industrial complexes.

> **EXAMPLE** Fos 4XL, the extension of the container terminals of Marseille-Fos. The military-industrial complexes of Brest, Cherbourg and Toulon.

V.3 Managing maritime spaces — and the verdict

Protecting the sea: protected areas and a constitutional ambition

With about 4,000 km of coastline and an EEZ of nearly 11 million km², France has a special responsibility for protecting the sea. Protected areas preserve fragile coasts and seabeds.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** The Scandola nature reserve in southern Corsica is a protected space. In July 2018, MPs voted to write the preservation of the seas and oceans into Article 34 of the Constitution, showing how much protecting its maritime spaces matters for France. (The constitutional reform that carried this amendment was in fact never completed — added from outside the course.)

A network of marine protected areas: 23.5% of French waters in 2019

France has built a dense network of marine protected areas (MPAs), the tool already met at world level in G1 (II.3). It grew very fast — especially in 2014 — and it lies mostly overseas, because almost all the French maritime space is there.

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** The course's infographic (French Ministry for the Ecological Transition, July 2019): 0.3% of French waters protected in 2006, 0.8% in 2009, 3.8% in 2013, 16.3% in 2014, 23.5% in July 2019, with 546 marine protected areas in mainland France and overseas. France is the 2nd maritime space in the world (over 10 million km²), and 97% of it is overseas. (The jump of 2014 comes from the Natural Park of the Coral Sea, created around New Caledonia — added from outside the course.)

Summary of the theme: maritime areas in globalisation

The course closes the theme with a summary map in three parts, which is also a ready-made plan. 1) A space of circulation: maritime highways between the three centres of the world economy, secondary routes, alternative Arctic routes as the pack ice melts, maritime façades. 2) Economic stakes: fishing grounds, offshore oil and gas fields, major ports — mostly Chinese — and the states with the largest maritime domains. 3) Strategic stakes: strategic passages, piracy zones, rivalries between coastal states over resources (the Arctic, the South China Sea).

> **EXAMPLE · OUTSIDE THE COURSE** On the course's map, the top three states by maritime domain are the United States, the United Kingdom and France, and the five leading states by fishing volume are China, Indonesia, Peru, Russia and the United States. The major ports are Rotterdam, Dubai, Singapore, Busan and the Chinese ports (Shanghai, Ningbo, Qingdao, Tianjin, Qinhuangdao, Guangzhou, Shenzhen, Hong Kong). Each part sends back to a chapter: G1 for circulation and resources, G2 for the Arctic and the rivalries, G3 for France. (Other rankings of EEZs put Australia and Russia ahead of the United Kingdom — added from outside the course.)

The verdict: a great maritime power, between power and fear of decline

Is France a great maritime power? Yes, through its EEZ (second in the world), its presence on every ocean, its navy (nuclear carrier and submarines) and its world-class companies and shipyards. But its ports are middle-ranking, its shipbuilding has declined, its equipment is costly to renew, and its maritime space is mostly made of distant territories. France stands “between power and fear of decline”.

> **EXAMPLE** The final video of the course: “La France, entre puissance et peur du déclin” (Le Dessous des cartes, 12 min). Strength: 10.7 million km² of EEZ; weakness: Marseille only 53rd port in the world.

Numbers

10.7 million km²
French EEZ, the second in the world

62% / 40%
Shares of the French EEZ in the Pacific / in French Polynesia alone

1
Nuclear-powered aircraft carrier — only France and the USA have one

4 + 5
Ballistic missile submarines + attack submarines

3rd
Rank of CMA CGM among the world's container shipping companies

3,000+
Employees of the Chantiers de l'Atlantique, builders of the biggest cruise ships

66
French ports

53rd / 68th
World ranks of Marseille and Le Havre by tonnage

4,000 km
Coastline of France, according to the course

2.5%
Share of the maritime economy in French GDP (about 300,000 direct jobs)

23.5%
Share of French waters covered by a marine protected area (July 2019; 546 MPAs)

97%
Share of the French maritime space located overseas

Vocabulary

FRENCH MARITIME POWER

Maritime power
A state able to control its coast and exert influence near and far (key term).

Overseas territories
French territories outside Europe, on three oceans, which make the EEZ.

Power projection
Ability to send forces far away: carriers, bases abroad.

SSBN
Ballistic missile submarine: carries nuclear deterrence.

SSN
Nuclear attack submarine (the Suffren).

Nuclear deterrence
Preventing attack by the threat of nuclear retaliation.

Arsenal
Naval base and shipyard of the navy (Toulon, Brest, Cherbourg).

Flag
The nationality under which a ship is registered.

EXTRAPLAC
French programme to extend the continental shelf beyond 200 nautical miles.

Operation Atalanta
European naval operation against piracy off Somalia.

Marine protected area (MPA)
Sea area where human activities are limited to protect nature (546 in France in 2019).

Maritime façade
A coastline lined with major ports and their hinterland, open to world trade (the Northern Range).